

# CLAWS Audit Report

[CLAWS](#)

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Auditor: Evelyn Upchurch

# Objective

I have chosen to audit the CLAWS website because it plays a crucial role in animal welfare by providing resources for cat adoption, rescue, and care. However, upon an initial review, the website presents several usability concerns that may impact its effectiveness in engaging users, delivering key information, and encouraging adoptions or donations.

Some key areas of concern include visual design, navigation clarity, mobile responsiveness, accessibility, and overall design consistency. As a site that serves a compassionate and community-driven mission, it is essential that CLAWS provides a seamless and engaging user experience to ensure potential adopters, volunteers, and donors can easily access the information they need.

## Business Context

### 1. Overview of CLAWS Website

The CLAWS website is an online platform dedicated to cat rescue and adoption. It serves as an informational and community-building resource, primarily for individuals and families looking to adopt cats, as well as for potential donors and volunteers. While the site's purpose is clear, the design and readability pose some challenges.

### 2. Purpose and Goals

The primary goal of the CLAWS website is to facilitate cat adoption by providing information about available cats, the adoption process, and ways people can support the organization through donations or volunteering. The site's homepage prominently displays its mission, reinforcing its dedication to cat rescue.

Additionally, the website aims to educate users about cat care and adoption through detailed content and images, strengthening its informational purpose.

### 3. Audience Analysis

#### Primary Audience:

- Families and individuals in Grand Junction seeking to adopt a cat.
- Cat lovers who may be interested in volunteering or donating to the rescue.
- The audience is identified through location information on the website and its clear adoption-oriented messaging.

#### Secondary Audience:

- Other animal welfare organizations and 501(c)(3) nonprofits.
- Potential partners or sponsors who support animal welfare initiatives.

#### 4. Design and User Experience

The website's design presents several usability concerns:

- **Issues:** The color scheme and layout make readability difficult, which detracts from user engagement.
- **Strengths:** The banner image scroll effectively showcases real cats available for adoption, reinforcing the site's purpose.
- **Navigation:** The navbar and button-driven navigation help users find relevant information, though improvements in layout could enhance accessibility.

#### 5. Content and Tone

- **Content:** The site includes essential information about cat adoption, the facility, and ways to get involved (donations, volunteering).
- **Tone:** The tone is a mix of formal and conversational, with occasional humor to keep it engaging. This balance makes the content professional yet approachable for potential adopters.
- **Effectiveness:** The content effectively aligns with the intended audience, speaking directly to cat adopters and supporters.

#### 6. Features and Accessibility Considerations

- **Functional Elements:** The site includes a navigation bar, multiple buttons linking to different pages, and an event calendar.
- **User Experience:** These features help users efficiently access relevant information but could be optimized for clarity and ease of use.
- **Accessibility Needs:** To better serve its audience, the website should consider implementing a screen reader-friendly design, contrast mode for readability, and improved tab navigation.

#### 7. Competitive Landscape

- The CLAWS website operates in a space with competition from larger organizations such as the Humane Society and other local cat shelters.
- Differentiation could be achieved through an improved user interface, clearer messaging, and stronger community engagement efforts.

#### 8. Final Assessment and Recommendations

While the CLAWS website successfully conveys its mission and provides useful resources, its design and readability issues hinder user experience. Improvements in layout, color contrast, and accessibility features would significantly enhance its effectiveness. Strengthening its competitive positioning through better content organization and engagement strategies could further amplify its impact in the rescue and adoption space.

## Persona-Driven Insights

### User Persona: Grant Campbell

#### Demographics:

- Age: 20
- Occupation: Learning Assistant & Student
- Location: Suburban area
- Technology Comfort Level: High

#### Goals & Motivations:

- Prioritizing mental health and mindfulness
- Seeking a summer internship
- Passionate about animal welfare and volunteering
- Engaging with meaningful digital experiences

#### Pain Points & Frustrations:

- Slowness and unresponsiveness
- Unintuitive layouts
- Outdated design
- Difficulty finding clear information on how to get involved with causes

#### Digital Behaviors:

- Primarily uses an iPhone and MacBook for browsing
- Prefers exploratory browsing, primarily via Google and Siri
- Utilizes accessibility features such as dark mode and subtitles
- Conducts research before making decisions
- Frequently searches for local volunteer opportunities and animal adoption resources

### First Impressions

- The homepage is bright and outdated, making it difficult to find specific information.
- The design does not feel welcoming or engaging for this persona due to its outdated style.
- The lack of clear volunteer or adoption CTAs reduces engagement.
- **Likely emotional response:** Annoyance or confusion due to poor visual hierarchy.

### Navigation & Usability

- Key information is somewhat accessible, but the text-heavy layout makes it difficult to locate details.
- Navigation is inconsistent, leading to potential frustration.
- The site is optimized only for desktop, which may hinder mobile accessibility.
- **Accessibility Issues:** Small text and formatting issues may cause readability problems, even though the persona does not have specific accessibility needs.
- **Missing clear callouts for adopting, fostering, or donating, which would engage an animal-welfare-focused user.**
- **Likely emotional response:** Frustration due to layout inconsistencies.

### Content & Messaging

- The language and tone are not offensive but lack engagement for someone primarily motivated by meaningful digital experiences and community involvement.
- The persona would appreciate stronger messaging around how they can help, including volunteer opportunities, adoption success stories, and donation transparency.
- **Information is available but difficult to access efficiently.**
- **Likely emotional response:** Mild annoyance at lack of clear information architecture.

### Interaction & Engagement

- While the persona is comfortable with technology, the website's interactive elements (buttons, menus) are poorly placed and inconsistent.
- The site does not provide clear feedback on errors or broken links, leading to confusion.
- Calls-to-action (CTAs) exist but do not stand out, making user engagement weaker than ideal.
- A well-placed "Get Involved" section would increase engagement.
- **Likely emotional response:** Frustration due to broken elements and lack of clear guidance.

### Emotional Journey Mapping

1. **Landing on Homepage:** Annoyed or concerned due to outdated visuals and cluttered layout, struggling to find volunteer or adoption opportunities.
2. **Navigating to the Volunteer Page:** Frustrated but slightly more engaged due to better layout, though unclear instructions may deter commitment.

3. **Visiting the Support Page:** Feeling more neutral, as this page is the most visually acceptable, but donation options need to be clearer.

## UX Recommendations Based on Persona Insights

1. **Visual Design Overhaul:**
  - Modernize the design to align with contemporary UI standards.
  - Enhance readability with better typography and contrast.
  - Include compelling imagery of animals to evoke empathy and encourage action.
  - **Why?** The persona values aesthetics and finds outdated designs off-putting.
2. **Improved Navigation & Layout:**
  - Simplify information architecture for quicker access.
  - Reduce clutter and optimize spacing for readability.
  - Add clear navigation for "Adopt," "Volunteer," and "Donate" sections.
  - **Why?** The persona dislikes unintuitive layouts and values efficient browsing.
3. **Mobile Optimization & Performance Enhancements:**
  - Improve responsiveness and ensure mobile compatibility.
  - Reduce page load times and address any existing bugs.
  - Ensure forms (for adoption, volunteering, and donations) are easily accessible and streamlined.
  - **Why?** The persona frequently uses mobile devices and is easily frustrated by unresponsiveness.

## Scope

- **Homepage**
  - i. First impressions and visual hierarchy.
  - ii. Clarity of navigation and messaging.
  - iii. Key calls-to-action (Adopt, Volunteer, Donate).
- **Adopt Page**
  - i. Usability of the adoption process.
  - ii. Clarity and completeness of pet profiles.
  - iii. Accessibility of forms and application process.
- **Relinquish Page**
  - i. Clarity of information on surrendering a pet.
  - ii. Ease of navigating the relinquishment process.
  - iii. Transparency regarding requirements and next steps.
- **Lost and Found Page**
  - i. Effectiveness of lost pet search features.
  - ii. Clarity of reporting and recovery steps.
  - iii. Accessibility of contact information for lost pet inquiries.

- **Support Page**
  - i. Transparency and clarity of donation options.
  - ii. Ease of completing a donation.
  - iii. Call-to-action effectiveness.
- **Foster Page**
  - i. Accessibility of fostering information.
  - ii. Clarity of steps to become a foster.
  - iii. Effectiveness of engagement strategies.
- **Volunteer Page**
  - i. Accessibility of volunteer opportunities.
  - ii. Clarity of steps to sign up.
  - iii. Effectiveness of engagement strategies.

## Heuristics

Using the provided heuristic evaluation framework, the CLAWS website was analyzed based on established usability principles. The key findings are as follows:

1. **Visibility of System Status**
  - No clear feedback when users submit forms (e.g., adoption applications, donations).
  - No loading indicators or success/error confirmations.
  - **Recommendation:** Implement status indicators and confirmation messages.
2. **Match Between System and the Real World**
  - The terminology is mostly user-friendly but could be improved for clarity in adoption processes.
  - Some icons and labels are unclear or inconsistent.
  - **Recommendation:** Use intuitive language and clear labels/icons that reflect user expectations.
3. **User Control and Freedom**
  - No obvious way to undo actions, such as accidental form submissions.
  - No "back" or "cancel" options in key flows.
  - **Recommendation:** Provide undo options and clearer navigation paths.
4. **Consistency and Standards**
  - Some inconsistencies in button styles, font sizes, and navigation structures.
  - Pages follow different layout rules, making the experience inconsistent.
  - **Recommendation:** Standardize UI elements for a cohesive experience.
5. **Error Prevention**
  - No inline validation for forms (e.g., incorrect email input is only flagged after submission).
  - **Recommendation:** Implement real-time error detection and confirmation prompts.
6. **Recognition Rather Than Recall**

- Some options are hidden in dropdowns, requiring extra effort to find them.
- **Recommendation:** Keep frequently used actions visible and accessible.
- 7. **Flexibility and Efficiency of Use**
  - No shortcuts or advanced options for returning visitors (e.g., login for frequent adopters/donors).
  - **Recommendation:** Introduce account features or personalized recommendations.
- 8. **Aesthetic and Minimalist Design**
  - The website contains cluttered sections and unnecessary elements.
  - The color contrast is weak in some areas, affecting readability.
  - **Recommendation:** Simplify the layout and improve color contrast.
- 9. **Help Users Recognize, Diagnose, and Recover from Errors**
  - Error messages are vague or missing.
  - **Recommendation:** Implement clear, action-oriented error messages.
- 10. **Help and Documentation**
  - Limited guidance on adoption, volunteering, or donation processes.
  - **Recommendation:** Add a comprehensive FAQ or help section.

## Design Review

### Key Insights

- The site structure lacks a modern grid system, making navigation and content organization inconsistent.
- The homepage prioritizes donations over adoption and volunteering, which may unintentionally push users away from engaging with other aspects of CLAWS.
- Cognitive biases such as **confirmation bias**, **framing bias**, and **status quo bias** affect how information is presented, limiting transparency and user accessibility.
- The visual hierarchy is weak on some pages, leading to confusion about key actions.
- Accessibility issues include inconsistent contrast, unclear typography hierarchy, and missing alternative text for some interactive elements.
- Interaction patterns are inconsistent, with missing feedback mechanisms for user actions.

### Impact Analysis

- **User Experience Issues:** Users may struggle to find adoption and volunteer information due to poor hierarchy and layout.
- **Potential Risks:** Missed engagement opportunities, lack of trust due to unclear financial transparency, and difficulty for first-time visitors to navigate the site.



- **Affected Groups:** First-time visitors unfamiliar with CLAWS, elderly users, and those with accessibility needs.

## Recommended Improvements

1. **Enhance Information Structure:** Improve navigation and prioritize adoption and volunteering sections alongside donations.
2. **Improve Accessibility:** Ensure WCAG-compliant text contrast, better spacing, and defined typography hierarchy.
3. **Modernize Visual Consistency:** Standardize buttons, fonts, and colors across all pages.
4. **Introduce Feedback Mechanisms:** Add hover states, form submission confirmations, and clearer interaction affordances.
5. **Clarify Messaging:** Define key terms (e.g., TNR) and simplify content presentation for better user understanding.

## Reflection

- **What was learned?** The site's emphasis on donations overshadows other engagement areas, while outdated design choices hinder usability and accessibility.
- **Future Design Direction:** Future updates should focus on clearer hierarchy, improved accessibility, and a more engaging, intuitive experience for all user types.

# Information Architecture Evaluation

## Participant Overview

- **Participant 1 (Emily H)**
  - Organized categories primarily under **Home**.
  - Created distinct categories like **Meet Your Bestfriend**, **Events**, **Directions**, and **Legacy Giving**.
- **Participant 2 (Will L)**
  - Focused on categories such as **Home**, **Adopt**, **Volunteer**, **Donate**, **Lost Pet**, and **Support**.
  - Grouped most items under **Home** and **Adopt**.

## Patterns and Similarities

- Both participants consistently used categories like **Home**, **Donate**, and **Support/Legacy Giving**.
- Differences emerged in the naming and grouping of adoption-related content.
- Emily introduced new categories such as **Meet Your Bestfriend** and **Events**.

- Participants often renamed categories to better match their understanding (e.g., **Legacy Giving** as **Donate**, **Meet Your Bestfriend** as **Adopt**).

## Areas of Confusion

- Cards like **Legacy Giving**, **Lost Our Home Pet Rescue**, **Memorial**, and **Facebook!** were difficult to categorize.
- Some categories, especially **Memorial** and **Legacy Giving**, didn't fit naturally within any participant-defined structure.

## Unexpected Findings

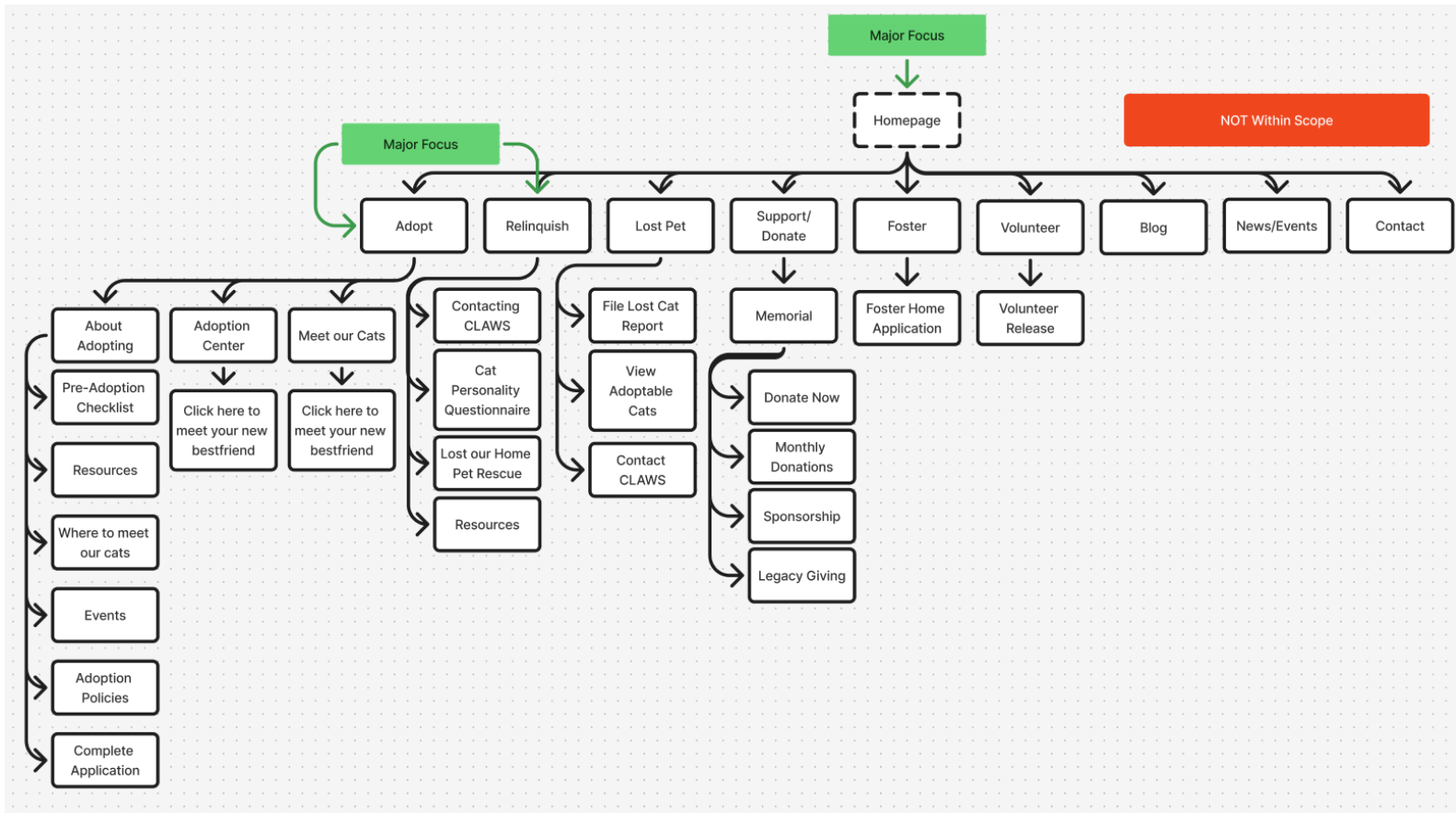
- Emily's categories like **Events** and **Directions** were unexpected but potentially useful.
- Participants grouped **Legacy Giving** under **Donate**, which may indicate a need for clearer terminology.
- There were differences in how participants perceived the adoption-related content.

## Comparison to Existing IA

- Will's structure closely resembled the current site map, while Emily's structure diverged but maintained the same core concepts.
- Participants' feedback indicated that some categories lacked clarity, especially regarding terminology.
- Adoption and fostering could be emphasized more clearly as the main purposes of the site.

## Actionable Recommendations

- **Clarify Page Titles:** Rename unclear categories like **Legacy Giving** and **Memorial** to be more intuitive.
- **Improve Content Organization:** Streamline the **Donate** and **Lost Pet** sections for easier navigation.
- **Emphasize Adoption and Fostering:** Make these the primary focus in the site's structure.
- **Conduct Further Testing:** Perform a **Closed Card Sort** to understand how users categorize content within set categories.
- **Usability Testing:** Evaluate how easily users can navigate the redesigned information architecture to ensure intuitive interaction.
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## Personal Insights

- The **Memorial** section might benefit from a clearer label like **Tribute Giving** or **In Memory Donations** for better understanding.
- **Meet Our Cats** could be integrated under **Adoption Center** to simplify the user flow.
- The **Support/Donate** section has a solid structure, but it may help to unify donation options for clarity.
- Some redundant categories like those under **Relinquish** and **Lost Pet** could be streamlined under a single “Help for Cats” category.
- For further validation, conducting usability tests can ensure that **Adopt** and **Donate** remain easy to find and use.

# Content Evaluation

## Clarity & Comprehension

- The main message is clear within 5 seconds.
- Some jargon and acronyms like "CLAWS" and "501(c)3" may confuse users unfamiliar with these terms.
- Certain buttons have unclear labels like "CATalogue," which offers no clear indication of its purpose.

## Readability & Scannability

- Font size, contrast, and line spacing are inconsistent, reducing readability.
- Excessive use of different fonts (up to six) creates visual clutter.
- Page headings are inconsistent, with buttons sometimes serving as headings, contributing to confusion.

## Conciseness & Efficiency

- Text is often verbose and could benefit from clearer, more concise messaging.
- Large blocks of text should be broken into smaller paragraphs or bullet points for better readability.

## Consistency & Predictability

- Style and tone fluctuate across different pages. For example, the 'Donate' page has an emotional tone, while the 'Adopt' page is more factual.
- Some inconsistent terminology (e.g., "Catalogue" vs. "CATalogue") diminishes professionalism.

## Tone & Voice Appropriateness

- The tone is generally friendly but inconsistent, with some pages sounding formal and others informal.
- Emotional language is sometimes effective but can verge on being overly dramatic on certain pages.

## Usability & Actionability

- Call-to-action buttons lack clarity, reducing their effectiveness.
- Navigation is difficult, with users often unsure of what to do next.
- Form submissions provide adequate confirmation, but further improvements in user guidance are needed.

## Error Handling & Feedback

- Error messages are generic, providing little context on how to resolve issues.

- There is a lack of detailed feedback for failed actions.

## Accessibility & Inclusivity

- The site lacks essential accessibility features, making it difficult for screen readers to interpret content.
- Poor color contrast and inconsistent text formatting create barriers for users with visual impairments.
- Instructions are not accessible to users with cognitive disabilities.

## Recommendations

- Prioritize readability improvements by adjusting font size, line spacing, and color contrast.
- Simplify and clarify the language across the site, avoiding jargon and reducing unnecessary text.
- Improve button labels for clarity and effectiveness.
- Ensure consistent tone and terminology across all pages.
- Provide actionable error messages with clear solutions.
- Implement accessible design practices, including screen reader compatibility and higher-contrast visuals.
- Introduce clearer navigation pathways to improve user experience.

Addressing these issues will significantly enhance clarity, usability, and accessibility, ensuring a more user-friendly experience.

# User Journey Evaluation

## Overview

The user journey for the adoption process on the evaluated website has a clear goal: to guide users through learning about adoption, selecting a cat, and submitting an application. However, the journey is hindered by unclear navigation, redundancy, and poor usability.

## Strengths

- **Logical Step Progression:** The general structure of the flow follows a reasonable sequence from exploration to decision-making.
- **Application Form Completion:** The final step is clear, with simple submission confirmation.

## Pain Points

1. **Navigation Challenges:**
  - Users encounter multiple pages with redundant information.
  - Inconsistent labels and links create confusion.
2. **Lack of Clarity:**
  - Key steps like learning about adoption and meeting a cat are not well-explained.
  - Users face difficulty choosing among different pathways without guidance.
3. **Technical and Design Issues:**
  - Pages, such as the CATalogue, fail to load consistently.
  - Poor formatting on the application form reduces usability.
4. **Feedback and Error Handling:**
  - Limited confirmation messages create uncertainty about progress.
  - Error messages provide minimal guidance for correction.

## Recommendations

- **Streamline Navigation:**
  - Consolidate redundant pages and ensure clear pathways.
  - Provide intuitive category labels and include breadcrumb navigation.
- **Enhance Clarity:**
  - Offer clearer instructions at critical decision points.
  - Provide visual guidance like progress indicators.
- **Fix Technical Issues:**
  - Ensure the CATalogue reliably loads.
  - Improve application form formatting for better readability.
- **Improve Feedback:**
  - Provide clearer confirmation messages and progress indicators.
  - Enhance error messages with actionable guidance.

## Conclusion

Addressing these issues will significantly improve the user experience, reducing confusion and frustration. Implementing clear guidance, minimizing redundancy, and resolving technical challenges will create a more efficient and satisfying adoption journey.

## Accessibility Evaluation

As part of my UX evaluation, I conducted a detailed accessibility evaluation of the CLAWSgj website. This process included automated testing using the WAVE tool as well as manual evaluations and testing that simulated real-world usage scenarios. Below are my findings and recommendations.

## Key Findings:

### 1. **Missing Alternative Text**

Across the site, several images either lack alternative text or use generic labels. Since images play a large role in communicating emotional appeal (e.g., adoptable cats), the absence of alt text creates a gap for users who are visually impaired and using screen readers.

### 2. **Low Color Contrast**

Various sections of the site, particularly in headers, buttons, and informational banners, use color combinations that do not meet WCAG contrast ratio standards. This creates barriers for users with color vision deficiencies or other visual impairments.

### 3. **Keyboard Navigation Issues**

While basic navigation is generally accessible via keyboard, dropdown menus, certain forms, and some interactive elements present difficulties. Inconsistent or missing focus indicators also make it hard for users to understand where they are on the page when navigating without a mouse.

### 4. **Non-Descriptive Interactive Labels**

Multiple links and buttons use vague or generic language like "Click here," or rely on icons without proper ARIA labels. For screen reader users, this can obscure the purpose of the element, making it harder to understand what action will be taken.

### 5. **Redundant Links**

Some pages feature multiple links leading to the same destination without differentiating context. This can be disorienting and unnecessarily repetitive for users using assistive technologies, reducing efficiency and clarity.

### 6. **Heading Text Issues**

Some pages had issues with the hierarchy of text, mainly with headings, creating issues for a screen-reader to be able to follow. This can be confusing and eventually debilitating to users who use a screen-reader, as it will either stop entirely, get stuck in a loop, or simply not read at all. .

## Recommendations:

- Implement descriptive alternative text for all meaningful images, particularly those used to convey content or serve navigational purposes.
- Review and adjust text and background color pairings to ensure they meet at least WCAG AA standards (4.5:1 contrast ratio for normal text, 3:1 for large text).
- Ensure all navigation and interactive elements can be accessed and clearly tracked via keyboard, with consistent visual focus states.
- Replace vague link labels with descriptive text that explains the function or destination of the action, and ensure icons have ARIA-labels or descriptive text equivalents.
- Eliminate or clarify redundant links to streamline the experience for screen reader users and improve overall usability.

- Fix headings and text title issues to follow correct hierarchy in the HTML so screen-readers or other automated scanning software can navigate through the content of a page without interruption or issue.

**Impact:**

Addressing these accessibility issues will ensure that CLAWSgi's digital platform is welcoming, inclusive, and usable for a wider audience, including those with disabilities. This is particularly important given the organization's mission to serve the community through compassion and advocacy for animals. An accessible website reinforces this mission by eliminating digital barriers and enabling more people to engage—whether through adopting a pet, making a donation, or volunteering their time. In addition to ethical and functional benefits, these changes also contribute to compliance with accessibility standards (such as WCAG) and bolster overall UX quality for all users.